the developing world from the Non-Aligned Movement and is an active participant in the BRICS grouping.

In South Asia, Indian leaders view themselves as the dominant power. India is the geographical, socio-cultural and economic centre of South Asia. New Delhi expects not just its neighbours but even external powers like China, the United States and the West both to accept Indian dominance as well as bear in mind India's interests in the region. Modern India expects its neighbours to consider India as the Chakravartin; South Asia is the only region where India has been willing to send its army or use force to defend its interests. The principle was applied during takeovers of the princely state of Hyderabad in 1948 and the Portuguese colony of Goa in 1961, while sending the Indian Peacekeeping Force to Sri Lanka in 1987, and also fighting four wars with Pakistan.

Yet, as ancient philosophers noted, the Chakravartin asserted primacy but never forcefully took over territory. Modern India too has never taken over territory that belonged to another neighbour. After the 1971 war with Pakistan that led to the creation of Bangladesh, India withdrew its forces within a short period of time from the territory of the new country.

India faced several challenges to being viewed as the dominant power in South Asia and its desire that neighbours look only to India and not to outside powers. Slow economic growth for decades meant that India did not have the economic clout to provide its neighbours with the assistance they needed. Fabian socialism, a mixed economy and the principle of economic autarky meant that until the 1990s India only grew at 3 per cent a year, a growth rate that precluded India's ability to assist neighbours. The growth of India's economy in the last two decades has opened the way for India offering aid to neighbours as an instrument of influence.

India's effort to woo its poorer South Asian neighbours with aid now face competition from China under the One Belt One Road (OBOR) initiative. China launched the China Pakistan Economic Corridor (CPEC) and has